The Resurrection of Wonder Woman

By Eleanor Vincent

ELEANOR: Pink from her bath and aglow with excitement, three-year-old Maya perched on the edge of the bathtub. I stretched out my arms and she jumped, landing in the white terrycloth towel I held out. Wrapping her in the towel, I draped a dry towel over my own shoulders and led her into our game.

The towels became two white capes. We ran from one end of our apartment to the other as our capes billowed behind us. Together we called, "Wonder Woman! Wonder Woman!" Exulting in our superpowers, we imagined we wore magic bracelets on our wrists and golden lariats around our waists, just like our heroine. The fantasy of being all-powerful ended at the side of Maya's bed, where I helped her into her nightgown and tucked her in, a little girl again. It was the 1970s, and I made a point of reading bedtime stories about exceptional women to her so that Maya would dream of daring and of genius. I hoped one day my daughter would become a woman who embraced her own power.

Sixteen years later, after a daredevil stunt left Maya in a coma, I wished I'd told her more cautionary tales.

4NG Fanatics

INTRODUCTION

More than 105,000 people await transplants in the United States today. Each day, on average, eighteen of them die waiting. If you had to answer the question "Would you consider organ donation?" for your nineteen-year-old daughter, how would you respond?

The Resurrection of Wonder Woman by Eleanor Vincent

ELEANOR: Maya's accident had happened three days earlier on a hot April afternoon. She had hiked to a meadow laced with oat grass and wildflowers. A ravine full of scrub oak and laurel trees tumbled down to a dry creek bed. One of her friends dared her to ride bareback on a horse they found there unfenced and unsecured. The animal reared and threw Maya to the ground with such force that she never regained consciousness.

I walked toward my daughter's bed, past the curtains surrounding families bent over other silent forms. After seventy-two hours of nursing my hope, willing my daughter to recover, an impossible thought dawned—***Maya might not make it*.** When I reached her bedside, I trembled with this new possibility. I took her hand in mine. *(to Maya)* Sweetheart, it's Mom. I've been telling you that you will get well. But maybe that's not right; maybe what I want isn't what matters . . . You decide, honey. I won't hold you back.

(to audience) As I stood looking down at the beautiful young woman she had become, I knew I had no magic bracelet, no supernatural powers. Neither did she.

I leaned into her and whispered the biggest lie of my life, never doubting she could hear me. *(to Maya)* I'll be all right, sweetheart, if you need to go.

As my determination dissolved, I wanted to throw myself across her chest and give in to hours of unsuppressed weeping. But then I had a new thought: ***If I break down, it will be too hard for her to die. My task now is to let her go*.**

4NG Fanatics

Maya's chest rose and fell. The ventilator hissed, the monitors beeped, a fiber optic cable snaked into her skull to measure the pressure inside her brain. A few hours later, her temperature soared.

DR. CARR: We did all we could. Would you consider organ donation?

ELEANOR: The question hung in the air for a long moment. In that instant I saw my baby the day she was born, pink and bald, her eyes squinting up at me as if the light might blind her. I saw my diabetic mother plucking at the sheets on her deathbed as her kidneys failed. I pictured families in other hospital conference rooms waiting for bad news. "Yes," I heard myself say. The love and energy I had poured into my daughter, her very life, must continue. I could no more accept that Maya was truly dead than I could fly to the moon or allow any vital part of her that could save another human being to go to her grave.

I trembled uncontrollably. I was about to give my daughter away in pieces. ***If I had fought harder, could I have held her here?***

******

ELEANOR: Across the San Francisco Bay, I later learned, a figure shrouded in white lay on a hospital bed, near death. The man's heart failure was so profound that his fingernails had turned blue. This man, comatose and oxygen-starved, was a blip on the computer screen of the national donor registry. Along with four thousand others on the heart transplant list, he was waiting for someone to die so that he could live. By his side, his wife watched the rise and fall of her husband's chest, the backs of her hands wet with tears she rubbed away without noticing. She turned her back on her husband's bed and prayed for a miracle. She didn't know it, but her prayer had just been answered in another hospital only thirty miles away on the other side of the San Francisco Bay.

Our donor coordinator was a young nurse, not many years older than Maya. She read me a list of Maya's vital organs as if they were car parts, asking permission to salvage each one.

4NG Fanatics

NURSE: Do you give consent for her corneas?

ELEANOR: Yes.

NURSE: Do you give consent for her lungs?

ELEANOR: *(in agony)* Look, I can save us both a lot of agony . . . Just take it—take it all.

NURSE: *(shaking her head)* The law requires that I must go through each one . . . I know this must be hard for you.

ELEANOR: It is *unbearable. (balling her hands into fists she smiles sardonically)* I am going to initial each of these blanks and sign this form here at the bottom. Then we are both going to agree that we did this legally. But I am not going to sit here while you read me a list of my daughter's organs. You have my permission to take anything that will save lives or reduce pain. Just don't make me stay here another minute.

*****

ELEANOR: As a "biomort," or a "beating heart cadaver," Maya was suspended in a nether world between life and death. Her brain would never function again, but with life support, her heart continued to beat and her chest rose and fell, filled with mechanically produced oxygen. Within minutes, "life support" became "organ

support." The ventilator still distended her mouth, but the cable that had run from the computer into her bandaged skull was gone. I slid my right hand under her shoulder and gazed down at her serene young face, playing with her warm fingers, now utterly still. My chest tightened as if something was squeezing the air from my lungs. I looked down at my lovely, lovely girl. *(to Maya in a whisper)* I love you, Maya. You are as beautiful to me as the day you were born. I'm letting you go now with all my heart, with all my love. *(to audience)* I put my head on Maya's chest. The rise and fall of her mechanically powered breath was like a whoosh of ocean tide—in and out, in and out. The steady drumming of her heart filled my senses. At last, I raised my head. There would be no last breath to signal the end. I simply had to walk away and leave her. I could not contemplate what would come next . . .

A few hours later, surgeons began to "harvest" my daughter's organs and tissues, work that continued through the night. I allowed doctors to take a hacksaw to my daughter's chest. They broke open her rib cage to extract her heart, her liver, and her kidneys.

NATIONAL

4NG Fanatics

******

ELEANOR: Twelve days after Maya died, I received a letter from our transplant coordinator, the young nurse I had treated so curtly. She told of the miracles that resulted from my decision. Maya's kidneys had been flown across the country to the Boston area. Her liver had gone to a thirty-eight-year-old woman with a rare form of liver disease. She was the mother of a seven-year-old daughter and would have died without the transplant. Maya's corneas had restored sight for two people in the Bay Area.

I burst into tears when I reached the paragraph about Maya's heart. It had been given to a fifty-four-year-old businessman. Tucked between the folds of the letter I found a note from his wife. She had not signed her name, but I could hear her voice through her words.

WIFE: My children and I want to express how thankful we are to you for the gift of life you have given us. My husband is getting better every day and the children, eight and twelve years old, have another chance to grow

up with a father. We will pray for you and your daughter every day.

ELEANOR: She signed it, "The Receiving Family." *(beat)* During the months that followed I would often pull out that ivory card with its neat, spiky letters and reread it, as if I could balance my grief against another family's joy, as if it were ballast enough.

*****

ELEANOR: Perhaps Maya was Wonder Woman, after all. She lived long enough to express her daring and genius more than most mortals. Maya was a gifted young actress. The day before her accident, she had learned about her acceptance as a community college transfer student into the UCLA School of Theater, Film, and Television, an honor granted very few. She was offered a full scholarship. She had been out celebrating, riding a strange horse bareback in a remote field.

She flew to the ground with her dreams and her beauty intact and lost consciousness instantly. The last time I spoke with her was the morning of the accident. I ruffled her hair on my way out the door. *(to Maya)* I'm

4NG Fanatics

so proud of you, honey. *(to audience)* She grinned up at me from the armchair where she was perched, still in pajamas, and gave me a Top Gun–style thumbs up. *(pantomimes this with a huge smile)* "Love you, Mom," she said. *(beat)* Love you too.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Eleanor Vincent
Book: At the End of Life, Pg 233
ISBN: 978-1937163044
Publisher: In Fact Books
Date (Month/Year): March 2012

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

NATIONAL USE